



Beyond All Recognition

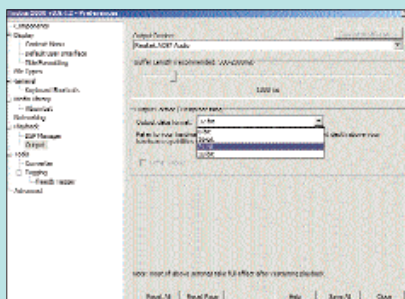
Start with foobar2000's Notepad-like interface and work your way up to a media player that's right up there with the rest

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Foobar2000 has been around for a while, but people tend to be turned off by the interface, which looks a lot like Notepad with a few buttons. Here, we'll give you a gist of the possibilities and things to do to reduce your Winamp withdrawal symptoms.

One step closer to Audiophilia

One of things you might hear from users of Foobar2000 is that it's far better than Winamp when it comes to quality of music. One of the reasons for these claims could be the 32-bit output depth ceiling—which, however also needs to be supported by your hardware. Higher bit



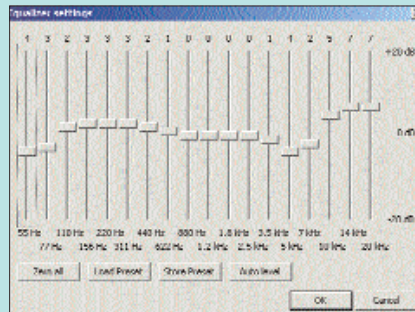
Set the output depth your hardware supports

depths mean more information can be recorded and played back. 32-bit is still pretty far-fetched even now, and most cards like the Audigy can only do up to 24 bits. Winamp is limited to a maximum of 24 bits as well but foobar2000 works with 32-bit float point, which along with dithering and noise shaping can give the tiny advantage that hardcore audiophiles want. To do this, go to **File > Preferences** and click on **Output** under **Playback**. You can alter the output data format to the bit depth supported by your hardware.

Note: Your sound card needs to support the bit depths you choose to use.

Equalizer

You also have an 18-band equalizer at your disposal, as opposed to Winamp's 10-band equalizer, which lets you get more accurate audio results. You can access the equalizer by going to **File > Preferences > Playback > DSP Manager**. Add Equalizer to Active DSPs and click on **Save All**. Click on **Configure** to open the Equalizer. Once added, you can access the equalizer from the main window by clicking on **View > Equalizer**.

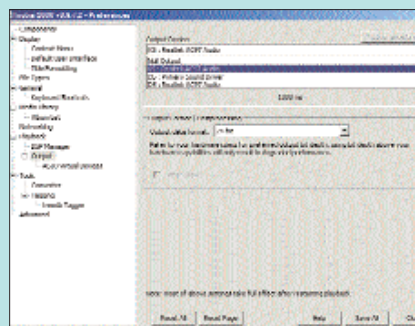


The 18-band equaliser

Kernel Streaming

Kernel Streaming skips the Windows mixer and is supposed to give better sound results than DirectSound. It also means that any volume control change in Windows will not alter foobar's volume.

The Kernel Streaming plugin does not come with Foobar2000 any more. You can download it from the Optional components section on Foobar2000's site—www.foobar2000.org. To install this plugin, download the zip files and unzip them into the components directory: `\foobar2000\components`. To enable Kernel Streaming, click on **File >**



Kernel Streaming: Leave Windows out of it

Preferences > Playback > Output. Click on the **Output Device** dropdown and choose **KS: "Your Sound device"**. Click on **Save All**.

Enhancing The Interface

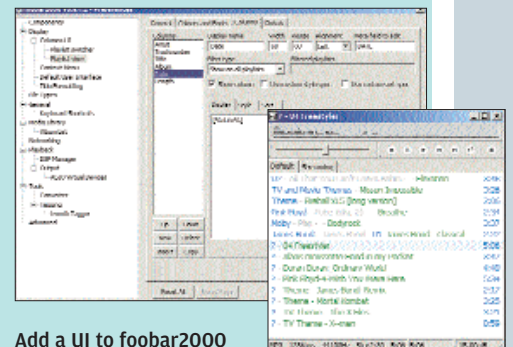
The biggest drawback of Foobar2000 is the dull interface. There are plenty of interface-enhancing plug-ins to give foobar2000 a complete makeover—one of the most famous is ColumnsUI.

ColumnsUI

Get ColumnsUI from <http://yuo.be/columns.php>. The installation of the plugin is as before—unzip the file into foobar2000's components directory, restart foobar2000 and you'll be

prompted to choose between the default foobar2000 interface and ColumnsUI. Volume control can be used by clicking on the current volume on the bottom-right of the window.

You can get readymade themes from the foobar2000 forums.



Add a UI to foobar2000

ReplayGain

Normalization is a process by evening out the differences in volume in either single tracks or albums. ReplayGain is a feature to do just this. ReplayGain is built into Foobar. You can alter the ReplayGain of tracks by right clicking on a particular track and clicking on **ReplayGain > Edit ReplayGain Info (advanced)**. Here you can manually enter the amount of amplification you want. Normalization for multiple tracks or albums can be done in a similar manner.

Keyboard Warrior

It's best to use the keyboard shortcuts to quickly change volume or track or start playing a random track. There is a default set of shortcuts already, and you can change or add more in **File > Preferences > General > Keyboard Shortcuts**. Create as many global shortcuts as possible—they will let you do tasks even while foobar2000 is minimised to the system tray.

There is a lot more to Foobar—a good place to start finding out is on the Foobar forums—<http://forums.foobar2000.org>. You'll find plenty of plugins and customised layouts to try out and modify for yourself. You can spend plenty of hours having fun with on Foobar—all you'll need is some patience and a willingness to experiment. ■

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